Al-Hussein Caluang

Hadji Al-Hussein Caluang (born May 16, 1947, in Kambing, Kalingalan Caluang, Sulu), widely known by his epithet "**The Lion of Mindanao**," was one of the most significant military figures in the history of the Bangsamoro armed struggle.

He is recognized as the **only Field Marshal** of the **Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF)**, a distinction conferred by the late MNLF Chairman Abul Khayr Alonto, and his life traces the full arc of the Bangsamoro experience: from the jungles of Sulu to international training grounds in Malaysia, Cuba, and Angola, and eventually into the halls of local governance and peace advocacy.

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BACKGROUND AND HERITAGE

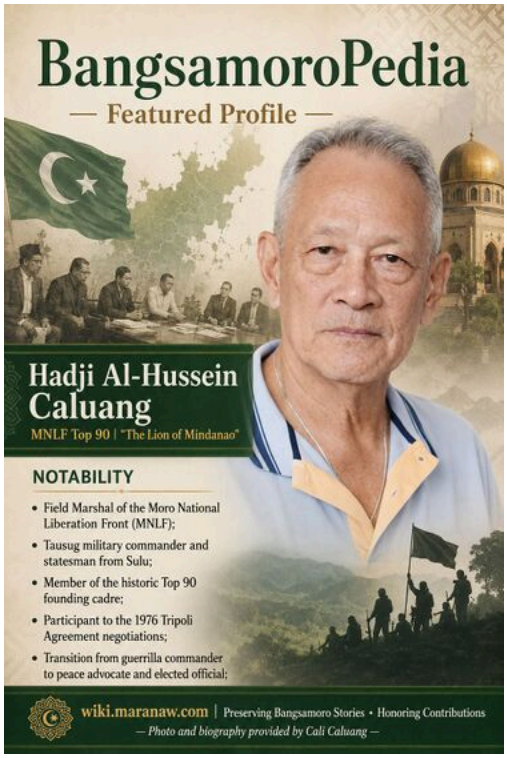
Hadji Al-Hussein Caluang was born on **May 16, 1947**, in Kambing, Kalingalan Caluang, Sulu, as recorded in his Certificate of Live Birth issued by the Office of the Civil Registrar General.

He was the firstborn child of his parents, delivered by a *hilot* (traditional midwife), and weighed 3,175 grams at birth.

His father, **Sayyid Captain Kalingalan Caluang**, was the chief police officer of the area, while his mother, **Lucia Ismael Jaudinez**, was a housewife. His parents were married in 1945 in Kambing, Kalingalan Caluang, Sulu, with his father at 23 and his mother at 20 years of age at the time of his birth. Both parents were Filipino citizens of the Islamic faith.

Caluang came from a lineage rooted deeply in the political and spiritual traditions of the Sulu Archipelago. He was a descendant of the sultans who governed Sulu until the arrival of the Americans in

Hadji Al-Hussein Caluang



Full Name

Hadji Al-Hussein Caluang

Also Known As

"The Lion of Mindanao"

Date of Birth

May 16, 1947

Place of Birth

Kambing, Kalingalan Caluang, Sulu, Philippines

Ethnicity

Tausug

Religion

Islam (Sunni)

Father

Sayyid Captain Kalingalan Caluang

Mother

Lucia Ismael Jaudinez

Affiliation

the late 19th century, placing him squarely within the long continuum of Moro resistance to foreign domination, from the Spanish and American colonial periods through the post-war era.

This heritage shaped his sense of identity and duty from an early age, making his later path into armed struggle less a departure from his roots than a continuation of them.

Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF)

Rank

Field Marshal (MNLF, sole holder of the rank)

Political Offices

Municipal Mayor, Kalingalan Caluang, Sulu; Member, Regional Autonomous Government Assembly of Region IX

Notability

The only Field Marshal of the Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF); Tausug military commander and statesman from Sulu; member of the historic Top 90 founding cadre

Known For

Armed resistance leadership during the Bangsamoro struggle; attendance at the 1976 Tripoli Agreement negotiations; transition from guerrilla commander to peace advocate and elected official

THE MNLF AND THE TOP 90

Caluang is one of the original members of the celebrated "**Top 90**," also called **Batch 90**, the pioneering group of volunteers who underwent intensive military training in **Pangkor Island, Sabah, Malaysia**, and formed the core command structure of the Moro National Liberation Front.

As part of the broader Third World liberation movement of that era, the MNLF drew support from Arab and Muslim countries, including Libya, which provided financial backing through zakat and international solidarity networks.

Following his training in Malaysia, Caluang was sent to **Cuba in 1971**, where he spent three months receiving specialized training in mass communication, recruitment, and both rural and urban warfare. This training was conducted under a general operating in close proximity to Fidel Castro's command.

He subsequently volunteered for deployment to **Angola**, where he and fellow dissidents from Asia, Europe, the Middle East, and Africa put their guerrilla training into practice against opposing military units.

Upon returning to Mindanao, Caluang applied everything he had learned and helped develop the MNLF's operational capacity in the field.

His reputation grew formidable. The late MNLF Chairman Abul Khayr Alonto would later describe him as the **only Field Marshal of the MNLF**, a singular distinction that earned him the enduring epithet "**Lion of Mindanao**." He was not only respected within the MNLF's ranks but was also, by many accounts, feared by the Armed Forces of the Philippines.

MARTIAL LAW AND RETURN TO THE FOLD OF THE LAW

Following the declaration of Martial Law under President Ferdinand Marcos, Al-Hussein Caluang was reportedly placed on a military blacklist, a reflection of how central his role had become in the armed resistance in Sulu.

As the political and security landscape shifted, senior MNLF leaders and commanders engaged in deliberations about the movement's future direction.

Acting upon the collective recommendations of MNLF leadership, including then Secretary-General Bakrin Lukman and other senior commanders, Caluang made the decision to **voluntarily return to the fold of the law**.

President Marcos had reportedly expressed a strong personal desire for Caluang's return, recognizing his singular importance as a field leader during the conflict in Sulu.

This decision was not a military surrender. It was, rather, a deliberate and negotiated step toward political engagement, marking an important turning point both in Caluang's personal journey and in the broader evolution of Bangsamoro conflict-to-peace efforts.

THE 1976 TRIPOLI AGREEMENT AND POLITICAL SERVICE

Caluang was present at the historic negotiations brokered by Libyan leader Muammar Gaddafi in the mid-1970s, which culminated in the **1976 Tripoli Agreement**, the landmark accord signed between the MNLF and the government of Ferdinand Marcos.

During this period, President Marcos reportedly asked Caluang to serve as his bodyguard during an official visit to the United States in the late 1970s.

After the Tripoli Agreement collapsed, Caluang and many of his contemporaries returned to the jungle to continue the armed struggle.

In **August 1975**, Caluang was appointed **Commander of the Paramilitary Force for Southern Luuk, Sulu**.

A few months later, **Presidential Decree No. 838** divided the Municipality of Luuk, Sulu into two municipalities to accelerate economic development in the area. The newly created municipality was named **Kalingalan Caluang**, in honor of his father, Sayyid Captain Kalingalan Caluang. Presidential Decree No. 838 was signed on December 6, 1975, by President Marcos.

Al-Hussein Caluang subsequently served as **Municipal Mayor of Kalingalan Caluang, Sulu**, bringing his family's name and legacy directly into the formal governance of the community that bore it.

He later served as a member of the **Assembly of the Regional Autonomous Government of Region IX**, marking his continued engagement in formal political institutions and cementing his transition from armed resistance to political participation.

LATER LIFE AND LEGACY

In his later years, Caluang became a vocal **supporter of the peace process** and expressed disagreement with certain approaches taken by former MNLF Chairman Nur Misuari, including the 2013 Zamboanga City siege.

While acknowledging Misuari's continued following, particularly in Sulu and Zamboanga del Norte, Caluang consistently advocated for dialogue and reconciliation within the MNLF.

He was among the MNLF pioneers who supported the reorganization of the MNLF under Chairman Alonto, a move endorsed by the 57-member **Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC)**.

Despite his age, Caluang retained an aura of authority and near-mythic reverence among the region's Muslims. Many held him in extraordinary regard, with some even believing him to be **impervious to bullets**, a testament to the kind of legendary status he had accumulated over decades of service and sacrifice.

The life and contributions of Hadji Al-Hussein Caluang continue to be studied in the fields of Bangsamoro history, peace and conflict studies, and political history. He stands as a compelling example of the intersection between traditional Islamic leadership, mass revolutionary struggle, and the long, difficult process of peace-building in Mindanao.

A tribute poem, "**But Lion's Name!**" was written by Prof. Neldy Jolo in his honor following his passing. It reflects the depth of reverence accorded to him within the Bangsamoro community.

THE CALUANG FAMILY

The Caluang family has played a sustained role in the political, spiritual, and cultural life of Sulu across multiple generations.

Sayyid Captain Kalingalan Caluang, father of Hadji Al-Hussein, was a distinguished statesman and community leader remembered as one of the "Fighting 21 of Sulu" and as the founder of Ansarul Islam. He served as OIC Governor of Sulu and is traditionally credited as the Magbabangun, the figure responsible for the continuation and organization of the Giba tradition during the enthronement of the Sultan of Sulu. He played a pivotal role in facilitating the enthronement of Sultan Jainal Abirin, following the reign of Sultan Jamalul Kiram II.

Hadji Al Hassan Caluang, grandson of Captain Kalingalan Caluang, served as OIC Governor of Sulu and played a quiet but significant role in the efforts that contributed to the **1996 Jakarta Peace Agreement** between the MNLF and the Philippine government. A Sunni Imam, he holds *ijazah* (authorization and certification) in the Science of Ihsan (Tasawwuf), including a rare comprehensive *ijazah* encompassing forty Sunni Sufi *turuq* (spiritual orders), a distinction seldom granted to a single individual and particularly unique within the Philippines.

Dr. Calingalan Hussin Caluang, son of Hadji Al Hassan Caluang, is recognized as the **Naqib al-Sadat al-Ashraf of the Philippines**. He is regarded as the first individual in the country since the arrival of Islam in the Philippine archipelago in the 13th century to formally hold this office with an authenticated *ijazah* in the Science of Nasab (Islamic Genealogy). He received this authorization from the Naqib al-Sadat al-Ashraf of Algeria and the Naqib al-Sadat al-Ashraf of Turkey, empowering him in the preservation, verification, and transmission of noble genealogical lineages. A dedicated student of the Islamic sciences, he has received multiple *ijazat* across various disciplines from respected scholars (*ulama*) in several countries, and continues to pursue advanced studies across the various *madhahib* (schools of Islamic jurisprudence).

SEE ALSO

- Moro National Liberation Front
- 1976 Tripoli Agreement
- 1996 Jakarta Peace Agreement
- Abul Khayr Alonto
- Nur Misuari
- Sulu Sultanate
- Organization of Islamic Cooperation
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Kalingalan Caluang, Sulu

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